

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Programming Language Popularity Rankings and Trends

Software engineering leads and technology strategists planning language adoption

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

R'26	R'25	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%

R'26	R'25	Language	Rating	YoY Change
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

The top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) collectively account for nearly 49% of the total index.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Top Gainers

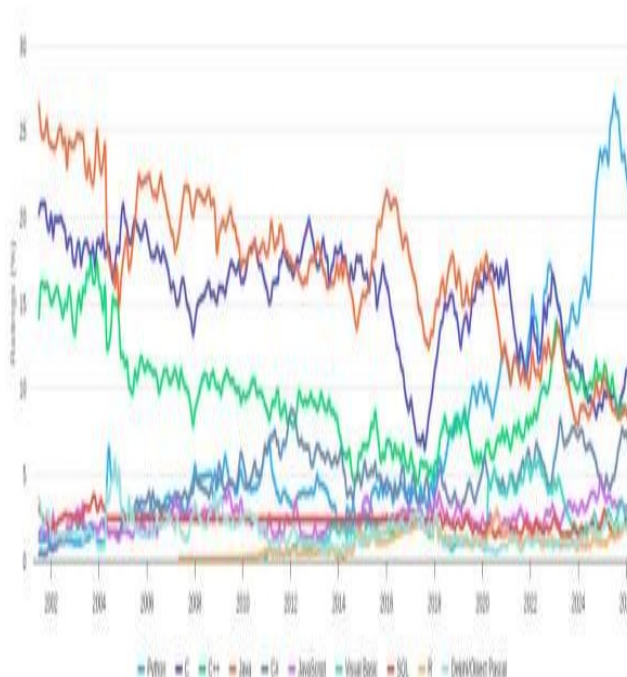
Perl	Up 13 spots (24th to 11th)	+1.0 5%
R	Up 7 spots (16th to 9th)	+0.9 4%
C	Up 2 spots (4th to 2nd)	+2.0 2%
Swift	Up 6 spots (26th to 20th)	+0.4 4%

Top Decliners

Go	Down 9 spots (7th to 16th)	-1.49 %
Python	Remains #1, but largest drop	-2.59 %
C++	Down 1 spot (2nd to 3rd)	-2.90 %
Java	Down 1 spot (3rd to 4th)	-2.37 %

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2



Source: TIOBE Index Historical Trends (2002-2026)

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

6

Times Python has won
Language of the Year
(2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)

Year	Language of the Year Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Key Observations:

- **C# is surging:** Won in both 2023 and 2025.
- **Go's historic peak:** Won in 2016, contrasting its current decline.
- **Data note:** 2017 winner is not available in source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

- **Python's Dominance vs Trajectory:** Python leads by a massive margin (21.25%), but its -2.59% drop highlights a slight cooling or shifting focus within the ecosystem.
- **C's Resurgence:** C's +2.02% growth suggests continued strong demand for systems programming, IoT, and embedded performance.
- **Legacy Revival:** Perl, Fortran, and R are growing, proving that entrenched enterprise and scientific systems remain highly relevant.
- **Go's Sharp Decline:** The massive drop for Go (-1.49%) may indicate displacement by Rust in the modern systems programming space.
- **Concentration Risk:** Python, C, C++, and Java hold nearly 50% of all mindshare. Over-indexing on niche languages brings talent availability risks.

Action: Audit your talent pipeline to ensure alignment with these long-term macro trends.